Professional Emails and Digital Communication

12 tips to develop an effective business writing style

1. Keep your purpose, readers and content in mind

? Purpose

What is my purpose?

- To inform
- To persuade
- To complain
- To appreciate
- To request
- To suggest or recommend
- To explain

Readers

Who are my readers?

- Supervisors
- Trainees
- Managers
- Others
- Assistants
- Technicians
- Employees

Content

- What information do my readers want?
- Will my readers understand technical terms?
- Would examples, details, or graphics help the readers to understand better?

2. Keep your sentences short

Long	Short
One of the best things you can do for yourself to improve your writing is to learn how to cut words that are not necessary. 25 words	To improve your writing, cut out unnecessary words. 8 words
Make your employees sufficiently aware of the potentially adverse consequences involved regarding these chemicals. 14 words	Warn your employees about these chemicals. 6 words
In view of the fact that the motor failed twice during the time that we tested it, we are at this point in time looking for other options. 28 words	Since the motor failed twice during testing, we are now looking at other options. 14 words

3. Use positive language

Negative	Positive
We are **unable** to promote you to supervisor because you **do not have** the skills and experience required for this position.	We will be able to promote you to supervisor when you meet the experience required for this position.
We **will not** start repairing your test equipment until we receive a deposit.	We will begin repairing your test equipment once we receive a deposit.
This is the second time that you **do not bother** to follow and stick to the duty roster.	This is to remind you again that your attendance is required.
If you **fail** to provide the specifications by the May 1 deadline, the project will **fail**.	By providing the specifications by May 1, you can be assured that the project will be on time.
You **cannot** reconnect without logging on again.	Log on again to reconnect.
The corporation **will not** pay unless employees also contribute.	The corporation will pay only if employees contribute.

4. Use Linking Words

Linking words help establish clear connections between ideas and ensure that sentences and paragraphs flow together smoothly, making them easier to read.

4. Use Linking Words

Function	Signals	Examples
Addition	And	• Your salary adjustment has been reviewed **and** approved by the operations committee.
	In addition	• **In addition** to cleaning the valve, the entire machine was inspected.
	Also	• The parts are cheap and they are **also** well made.
	Moreover	• The supplier will deliver the unit. **Moreover**, he will supervise its installation on site.
	Furthermore	• You are requested to submit the drawing for the Gas Project. **Furthermore**, inform us of the starting date.

Function	Signals	Examples
Cause and Effect	Because (of)	• The flight was delayed **because of** fog.
	Due to	• Internet users had a hard time accessing the web **due to** the international hacking competition yesterday.
	Therefore	• The pay rate is not clearly defined. **Therefore**, it is recommended that the contract should not be signed yet.
	As a result	• The morale and overall capabilities of our trainees have shown a remarkable improvement **as a result** of your efforts.
	Consequently	• The spare parts did not arrive on time. **Consequently**, I contacted the suppliers.

Function	Signals	Examples
Contrast	But	• The software is expensive, **but** it meets our requirements.
	However	• The meeting scheduled for Monday was cancelled. **However**, we will meet sometime next week.
	Yet	• This is acceptable, **yet** it could be better.
	Although	• **Although** no complaints have been received, we think that the use of the internet must now be monitored.
Purpose	In order to	• We are writing to you **in order to** clarify certain confusing points.
	So that	• The new employees must be trained in a practical hands-on manner **so that** we can bring their performance up to acceptable levels.
	So	• Our office printer is running low on ink, **so** please refrain from printing unimportant documents for the time being.

5. Use simple, familiar words

Unclear	Clear
He **discerned** that the **promulgated** policy would work.	He **knew** the **proposed** policy would work.
As **stipulated**, we **extrapolated** the budget figures for two years.	As **required**, we **estimated** the budget figures for two years.
Will you **utilize** instruction manuals during the **obligatory** training period?	Will you **use** instruction manuals during the **required** training period?
We **anticipate** that most of the options will be **fundamental** enough to meet our needs.	We **expect** that most of the options will be **basic** enough to meet our needs.
Remember to **incorporate** all the other good writing principles you have learned in this course.	Remember to **include** all the other good writing principles you have learned in this course.

6. Use passive voice for specific reasons

The choice between using active or passive voice in business writing is a matter of style. Most books recommend using active voice. However, there is an exception to this rule.

6. Use passive voice for specific reasons

When to use the passive voice?
The passive voice is to be preferred in the following cases:

1. Use the passive voice when you do not want to identify who performed the action.



Examples:

- Smoking is prohibited.
- A new safety policy was introduced after the accident.
- The new offices were decorated last week.
- The error has been corrected.
- The centrifugal pump was installed on May 12, 20xx.
- Procedures have been written to ensure safety.

6. Use passive voice for specific reasons

2. Use the passive voice to describe a mistake to avoid blaming anyone in particular.



Examples:

- Profits are down by 2%.
- The incident rate in ABC Field is increasing dramatically this year compared to last year.
- Computer sales dropped by 10 % during the summer.
- The monthly report was submitted late.

6. Use passive voice for specific reasons

3. Use the passive voice when you don't know who carried out the action.



Examples:

- Three computers were stolen from the training center.
- The training room was left unlocked.
- The briefcase was stolen at the airport terminal.
- The photocopier is broken.

7. Use bullet points and numbered lists correctly

Bulleted lists:

When to use bulleted and numbered lists

Use numbered lists when working with instructions that are to be carried out in sequence. If the sequence of items is not essential, use bullets.



Example 1: Using bulleted lists

We are still having problems with the five new computers we have purchased from XYZ Computer Company. The problems we have been having include:

- Two notebook computers won't boot up.
- One monitor continues to make a high-pitched, whining sound.
- Two desktop computers became infected with viruses.



Example 2: Using bulleted lists

I raised your difficulty about arriving for work on time. I pointed out that:

- your managers had done their best to take account of your travel problems; and
- you had agreed with them that Dubai was the most convenient place for you to work.

However, your initial improvement was short-lived. Over the past two months your punctuality has dropped to a totally unacceptable level.

By using bulleted lists, you draw your reader's attention to important items.

7. Use bullet points and numbered lists correctly
Numbered Lists

By using numbers, you are directing your reader to carry out instructions in sequence.



Example 3: Using numbered lists

To: Amar Jones
From: Khaled Mohamed
Date: March 5. 20xx
Subject: Procedure for Handling Payroll Advances

There is a new procedure (to reflect updated policies) for obtaining payroll advances. Our employees will find it an improvement on the old confusing procedure. The new procedure is as follows:

1. Obtain form for Payroll Advance from your supervisor.
2. Complete the form by filling in all the blanks in the Employee Section form.
3. Get approval from your immediate supervisor.
4. Pick up your check from the cashier's office.



Example 4: Using numbered lists

To: All Employees Using XP 2000 Computers
From: Head of Information Technology
Date: March 5, 20xx
Subject: Computer Security Problem

Your cooperation is urgently needed to solve a serious computer security problem. To enable you to keep your files and those of the entire company secure, please follow these two actions:

1. Keep your password private and do not share it with anyone.
2. Log on to the computer manually.

Your adherence to the above is much appreciated.

7. Use bullet points and numbered lists correctly

Put lists of items in parallel form

Use parallel form to improve the clarity of your writing. To make your writing parallel, use the same grammatical form for all items in a list.
In other words, match nouns with nouns, verbs with verbs, and phrases with phrases.



Example: Parallel form in lists

Here are two versions of a passage. The first ignores the guidelines; the second follows them.

Weak List	Improved List
I left my job for several reasons: • Long hours • Poor pay • I found the work tedious • Equipment was dangerous	I left my job for several reasons: • Long hours • Poor pay • Tedious work • Dangerous equipment
The following preliminary work is required before work-over: 1. Remove pen-fold fence. 2. Removing crash barrier. 3. Clear cellar of sand. 4. Remove safety valve. 5. Master valves need to be checked for leakage.	The following preliminary work is required before work-over: 1. Remove pen-fold fence. 2. Remove crash barrier. 3. Clear cellar of sand. 4. Remove safety valve. 5. Check master valves for leakage.

8. Use tables and charts effectively

Tables, charts and other graphs are quick, effective ways for your reader to get information. People don't always read everything in a report, but they often look at the visuals.

In this section, we will concentrate on when to use tables and charts effectively to enhance your written presentation and to draw your readers' attention.

Tables

Use a table to present data and facts to improve clarity.



Example:

Department	Current Month	Year to Date
Drilling	$ 2,000	$ 5,000
Inspection	$ 1,200	$ 4,300
Operations	$ 3,300	$ 10,000
Safety	$ 1,200	$ 2,500
Technical	$ 3,000	$ 5,200
Total	**$ 10,700**	**$ 27,000**

Table 1.1 Overtime expenses for all departments

8. Use tables and charts effectively

Charts

The following charts are commonly used in technical reports:

- Line chart
- Pie chart
- Bar chart
- Flow chart

Line chart

Use a line chart to show trend data over extended time periods.

Example of line chart

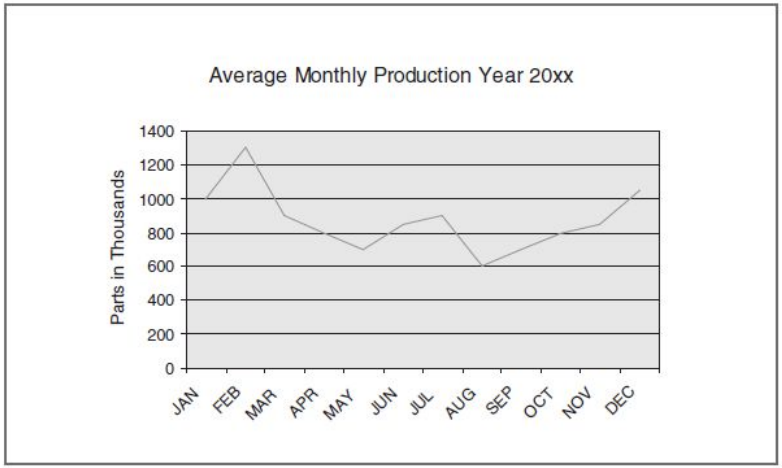


Figure 1.2 Line chart

8. Use tables and charts effectively

Pie chart

Use a pie chart to show percentage or distribution of a whole.

Example of pie chart

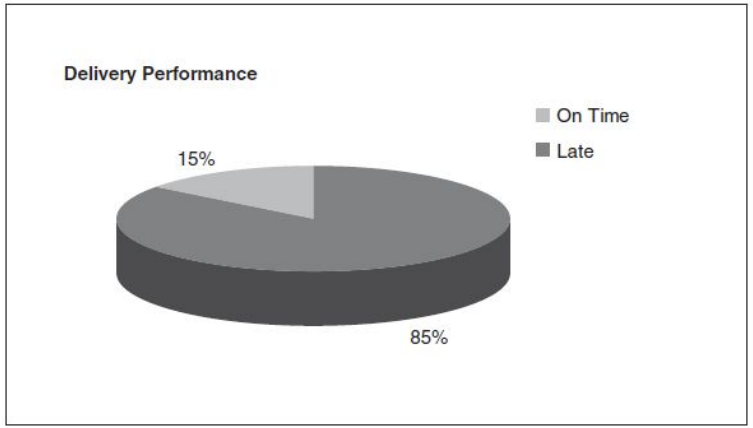


Figure 1.3 Pie chart

Flow chart

Use a flow chart to show a series of steps from beginning to end (e.g. procedure or process).

Flow chart symbols

Name	Symbol	Meaning
Oval		Start or end of the task
Rectangular		Steps
Diamond		Decisions
Flow line		Used to connect symbols and indicate the flow of logic

9. Use impersonal style when expressing opinions

Expressions like “I think” or “I feel” are rarely used in business reports because they are too personal.
Managers are not looking for your personal opinion and feeling; they are looking for professional opinions.

Personal Style	Impersonal Style
I believe a bonus for our employees should be based on employees' performance.	The bonus for our employees should be based on employees' performance.
I expect that the use of computers will make it easier to compile our monthly production report.	The use of computers will make it easier to compile our monthly production report.
I feel certain that the new plan is better than the old method.	The new plan is better than the old method for the following reasons:
I think that by taking this course, it will help improve my writing skills. I know that I will learn how to use skills that are good to know in any job.	This course should improve my writing skills, teaching me skills that are good to know in any job.
I would like to recommend that everyone wear safety boots in the Power Station.	It is recommended that everyone wear safety boots in the Power Station.

10. Avoid outdated expressions

Here are some classic examples of outdated expressions to be avoided in business writing. Use modern language instead which is shorter and clearer.

Instead of this . . .	Try this . . .
Please send your comments not later than (date).	Please send your comments by (date).
Please find attached herewith . . .	Attached is . . .
Enclosed please find . . .	Enclosed is . . . or I have enclosed . . .
Please feel free to contact the undersigned on . . .	Please call me on . . .
As per your request . . .	As requested . . .
In accordance with your request . . .	As you requested . . .
We are hereby acknowledging receipt of your order . . .	We received your order . . .
Please be good enough to advise me . . .	Please let me know . . .
I would be glad if you could advise me when . . .	Please let me know when . . . .
Pursuant to your e-mail . . .	According to your e-mail . . .
I am writing this e-mail to convey my warmest congratulations on your	Congratulations on your promotion to . . .

11. Avoid repetition

Repetition	Without Repetition
I think **the reason why** Lucas has been promoted to operations manager is **because** of his performance.	Lucas has been promoted to operations manager **because** of his performance.
We do not have the manpower to **carry out the major overhaul of the gas turbine** or the spare parts to **carry out the major overhaul of the gas turbine**.	We have neither the manpower nor the spare parts to **carry out the major overhaul of the gas turbine**.
I ask **the question whether** trainees can attend the gas turbine course.	I ask **whether** trainees can attend the gas turbine course.
Each **individual operator** will receive a bonus for completing the task on time.	Each **operator** will receive a bonus for completing the task on time.
Our Human Resources department is **planning in advance** a meeting to review the effectiveness of the new appraisal system.	Our Human Resources department is **planning** a meeting to review the effectiveness of the new appraisal system.
The August 8 meeting has been **postponed to a later date**.	The August 8 meeting has been **postponed**.

12. Avoid turning verbs into nouns

Noun Form	Verb Form
give instructions to	instruct
make a classification	classify
carry out an investigation of	investigate
perform an assessment	assess
make an observation	observe
conduct a review of	review
make adjustments	adjust

Business Emails

1. Write a clear subject line

Write the subject lines clearly to let the recipient know what the message is about. What you write in the subject lines should reflect the content of the e-mail.

See the examples below on clear and unclear subject lines.



Example 1

Subject: Seminar (**Not Clear**)
Subject: Security Management Seminar held by Siemens (**Clear**)



Example 2

Subject: Photocopy Machine (**Not Clear**)
Subject: Authorization for Photocopy Machine Purchase (**Clear**)



Example 3

Subject: Information (**Not Clear**)
Subject: Request for Salary Information (**Clear**)

2. Use the "cc" button

Use the "cc:" button for those individuals who need the information, but who would not be required to reply to your e-mail or take any action.



Example

From: jassim@climaxtech.com
To: ali@climaxtech.com
CC: hassan@climaxtech.com; lila@climaxtech.com
Subject: Safety Training Modules Presentation

Ali,

Please be prepared to make a ten-minute presentation on "Safety Training Modules" to all employees on June 15, 20xx, at 10.a.m. in the conference room.

Regards,

Jassim Mohammed
Safety Manager

In this e-mail Mr. Jassim requests Ali to deliver a presentation and he sends copies to Hassan and Lila for their information only.



- "**To**" is expected to respond.
- "**CC**" is expected to read the message as information only.

3. Use the Out of Office Assistant

The Out of Office Assistant automatically replies to email messages sent to you during your absence. By using this tool you can acknowledge receipt of the message, and advise the sender when you will be back at work and able to respond to their messages.

How to use the Out of Office Assistant

You can use this method from any computer that runs Microsoft Outlook.

1. Click on the **Tools** menu.
2. Select **Out of Office Assistant**.
3. Click on **I am currently out of the office** and enter a suitable message to be sent in your absence.
4. Click on **OK** to save the settings.
5. Repeat these steps and click **I am currently in the office** when you return.



Example:

From: jassim@climaxtech.com
To: khalid@climaxtech.com
Subject: **Out of the Office Auto Reply**

I will be out of the office from March 10 to15, attending the Gas Turbine conference.

Please contact Ali during the abovementioned period.

Jassim Hammed
Operations Supervisor

Use this feature when you are out of the office for a few days or when you are on leave.

4. Use attachments for long documents

Since not all computers have the same type of software, you should inform readers which program or software is needed to open your attachment.

It is best to inform your readers of the format of any **attachments** you send if they're anything other than basic Microsoft Office file types.



Example:

To: Mike@climaxtech.com
CC: Ahmad@climaxtech.com
Subject: ABC Company Profile
Attachment: ABC Company Profile. PDF (90K)

Dear Mike,

Please find attached ABC® Company Profile.
Should you have any questions, please contact me on my mobile: 050/4434660.

Note: You require Acrobat Reader to open the attachment.

Regards,

Adel Ahmed
Consultant



- Before sending an attachment, consider whether your reader has the software to open and view the file.
- Be careful of file sizes; use zip files for extra large attachments.

5. Keep your message short

E-mail is meant to be brief. Keep your message short and to the point. Use only a few paragraphs and a few sentences per paragraph. (For further information, see Chapter 1, section 2.)

6. Don't use e-mail for immediate action

Don't use e-mail if you need an immediate reply or action. Remember that the person you are sending e-mail to may be in a meeting, out of office, or taking leave or absent. For any of these reasons, they may not be able to reply to you immediately.

For immediate responses use another, more personally direct means of communication such as mobile or telephone.



E-mail is a great way to quickly get information to many people, but may not be the right answer for all communications.

7. Use spell check

Some employees do not check their spelling before sending an e-mail. It only takes a few seconds to run a spell-check to pick up any spelling errors. This may influence whether your message is read, ignored or responded to.

Frequently misspelled business words

absence	accommodate
approximately	attendance
behavior	colleague
committee	competent
decision	develop
dilemma	discipline
efficiency	environment
existence	familiar
guarantee	guidance
immediately	maintenance
maneuver	millennium
relevant	technique

8. Use courteous language

Read the e-mail below and consider how you would feel if you were the reader. Then compare it with the revised e-mail which is written in a polite way.



Example

Original

	From: jassim@climaxtech.com To: ali@climaxtech.com Subject: Work Permit
No greeting	
Impolite message	I am no longer responsible for dealing with work permits so do not allow your staff to bring these permits to my office anymore. Let your staff contact Hassan from now on for all permit matters.
No closing	

Revised

	From: jassim@climaxtech.com To: ali@climaxtech.com Subject: Work Permit
Appropriate greeting	Dear Ali,
Positive message	I have just transferred to the Training department. Please inform your staff to deal with Hassan from now on. Your co-operation is appreciated.
Appropriate closing	Regards, Jassim Hamad Training Coordinator

9. Provide an action statement when necessary

At the end of your e-mail you should conclude with an action statement. What specifically, do you want your readers to do as a result of reading your e-mail?

Do you want them to reply to your e-mail, or is it for their information only?



Example

To: All employees
CC:
Subject: Virus–Caution

We have identified a virus in the form of an attachment with the word "Love", which will try to run itself, without the knowledge of your friends, partners or vendors.

Therefore, do not open any e-mail or save any attachment having the word "Love," even if it is from your trusted friends, partners, or vendors.

Action Statement

Regards,

Ali Salem
Information System Manager

10. Identify yourself clearly

When contacting someone outside your organization, always include your name, occupation title, contact number and any other contact information. This will help your reader to respond to you better.



Example

To: sam@climaxtech.com
CC:
Subject: Risk Management Seminar

Dear Sam,

Regarding our telecom conversation today, the Risk Management Seminar will be held in Dubai on May 15, 16, and 17.

To register for the seminar, please e-mail: events@climaxtech.com
Regards,

Ali Hammed
Accounts Director
Phone: (02) 232-5693
E-mail: alimm@labc.org

Include your name, job title, phone number and e-mail address when you send an e-mail outside your company.

11. Do not overuse abbreviations

Imagine you receive the following message, which uses many abbreviations.



Example:

To: hassan@climaxtech.com
CC: lila@climaxtech.com
Subject: Risk Management Seminar
Attachment:

Ali,

Plz be informed that **u** are nominated **2** attend the Risk Management seminar which will be held @ Hilton Hotel in Dubai from May 15-20, 20xx.

Let me know if **u** need more **info**.
Regards,

Ahmed Mohamed
Training Coordinator

The sender of this message uses many abbreviations such as **Plz** instead of please, **U** instead of you, **2** instead of to, @ instead of at and **info** instead of information.

These abbreviations are acceptable in messages to close, personal friends, but are not appropriate in business e-mails. They often make the readers frustrated when trying to read your messages.

12. Do not use all capitals when typing

The original e-mail presented below is difficult to read and gives the reader the impression that they are being shouted at. Use capital letters to highlight an important word, but don't type your e-mail entirely in capital letters.



Example:

Original

From:
To:
Subject: Employee of the Month Program

DEAR ALI,

STARTING IN OCTOBER WE WILL BEGIN RECOGNIZING A DIFFERENT EMPLOYEE FROM EACH DIVISION AS EMPLOYEE OF THE MONTH. SELECTION WILL BE MADE BY DIVISION MANAGERS AND WILL BE BASED ON THE FOLLOWING CRITERIA:

- PERFORMANCE OF DUTIES
- ATTENDANCE
- ATTITUDE